DPSH MUN 2026

DISEC

Securing Peace, One Resolution at a Time.

DISARMAMENT AND INTERNATIONAL SECURITY COMMITTEE

DPSH MUN 2026

AGENDA:

“Assessing the Risk of Nuclear Proliferation in the South Asian Region.”

Letter from the Executive Board (EB)

Greetings Delegates!
Hope you all are doing well.

We are very pleased to welcome you to the simulation of the UNGA: DISEC at DPSH MUN'26. It is an honour to serve as your Executive Board for the duration of the conference. This Background Guide is designed to give you an insight into the case at hand, so we hope this acts as only a catalyst for furthering your research, and not limited to just this guide. Please refer to it carefully. Remember, a thorough understanding of the problem is the first step to solving it.

Do understand that this Background Guide is in no way exhaustive and is only meant to provide you with enough background information to establish a platform for beginning the research.

Delegates are highly recommended to do a good amount of research beyond what is covered in the Guide. The guide cannot be used as proof during the committee proceedings under any circumstances.
We understand that MUN conferences can be an overwhelming experience for first-timers but it must be noted that our aspirations from the delegates are not how experienced or articulate they are. Rather, we want to see how one manages the balance to respect disparities and differences of opinion and work around this while extending their foreign policy to present comprehensive solutions without compromising on their self-interests and initiate consensus building.

New ideas are by their very nature disruptive, but far less disruptive than a world set against the backdrop of stereotypes and regional instability due to which reform is essential in policy making and conflict resolution. At any point during your research, do not hesitate to contact the Executive Board Members for clarifications or in case you need help in any other aspect. We look forward to a fruitful discussion and an enriching experience with all of you.

Best regards,

Chairperson- *Suraj Veerubhotla*

Important Points to Remember

A few aspects that delegates should keep in mind while preparing:

1. **Procedure:** The purpose of putting in procedural rules in any committee is to ensure a more organized and efficient debate. The committee will follow the UNA-USA Rules of Procedure. Although the Executive Board shall be fairly strict with the Rules of Procedure, the discussion of the agenda will be the main priority. So, delegates are advised not to restrict their statements due to hesitation regarding procedure.

2. Foreign Policy: Following the foreign policy of one's country is the most important aspect of a Model UN Conference. This is what essentially differentiates a Model UN from other debating formats. To violate one's foreign policy without adequate reason is one of the worst mistakes a delegate can make.

3. Role of the Executive Board: The Executive Board is appointed to facilitate debate. The committee shall decide the direction and flow of debate. The delegates are the ones who constitute the committee and hence must be uninhibited while presenting their opinions/stance on any issue. However, the Executive Board may put forward questions and/or ask for clarifications at all points of time to further debate and test participants.

4. Nature of Source/Evidence: This Background Guide is meant solely for research purposes and must not be cited as evidence to substantiate statements made during the conference. Evidence or proof for substantiating statements made during formal debate is acceptable from the following sources:

b. Government Reports: These reports can be used in a similar way as the State Operated News Agencies reports and can, in all circumstances, be denied by another country.

United Nations: Documents and findings by the United Nations or any related UN body is held as a credible proof to support a claim or argument. Multilateral Organizations: Documents from international organizations like OIC, NATO, SAARC, BRICS, EU, ASEAN, the International Court of Justice, etc. may also be presented as credible sources of information.

c. News Sources

1. Reuters: Any Reuters article that clearly makes mention of the fact or is in contradiction of the fact being stated by a delegate in council.
2. State operated News Agencies: These reports can be used in the support of or against the State that owns the News Agency. These reports, if credible or substantial enough, can be used in support of

or against any country as such but in that situation, may be denied by any other country in the council. Some examples are – RIA Novosti (Russian Federation), Xinhua News Agency (People's Republic of China), etc.

****Please Note: Reports from NGOs working with UNESCO, UNICEF and other UN bodies will be accepted. **Under no circumstances will sources like Wikipedia, or newspapers like the Guardian, Times of India, etc. be accepted.** However, notwithstanding the criteria for acceptance of sources and evidence, delegates are still free to quote/cite from any source as they deem fit as a part of their statements.*

Guidelines

- Read the entirety of the background guide in the order it was written. Make sure to highlight the names of specific treaties, documents, resolutions, conventions, international bodies, events and any other specific incidents so that you can get back to them later and do a lot more thorough research.
- Understand some of the basic details regarding the country that you've been allotted whether this be the capital, current affairs regarding geopolitical situation, political hierarchy etc. While not strictly necessary, you never know when this can turn out to be handy. Geography Now's A - Z Country List has been a particularly helpful resource for this.
- Use a search engine of your choice to create as many tabs as possible for the highlighted terms from your background guide. Wikipedia or a YouTube video act as a great way to get a brief summary of the incidents at hand but such sources (especially Wikipedia articles) cannot be used in committee as sources.
- Delve into deeper research regarding the particular position of your allocation with the agenda at hand. Try searching for the voting stances of your allocation in related conventions and understanding the reasons for voting as so. UN Press Releases are also a helpful source for this matter.
- Find the website for the foreign ministry of the country you have been assigned alongside the "Permanent Mission of COUNTRY to the United Nations" website and search for a key term relating to the agenda, this should often give you statements from recent press conferences or UN committee sessions that can act as valuable sources of information in forming a position.
- Keep a handy copy of the Charter of the United Nations, whether as a .pdf file extension or a physical copy works. This contains the founding principles of the

United Nations and contains articles that lay out the mandate of the six bodies that the United Nations is primarily divided into. Spend some additional time researching the specific mandate and functions of the committee that you have been assigned.

- The Executive Board may ask for the source of a statement that a delegate makes in committee either during a Point of Order circumstance or if said statement stands to be of interest to the Executive Board. Therefore, it is recommended that delegates keep track of their sources when making / disputing a claim and also ensure their validity. Please do remember that while you as a delegate are allowed to cite any source you wish during committee.

Hierarchy of evidence

Evidence can be presented from a wide variety of sources but not all sources are treated as equal. Here's the hierarchy in which evidence is categorised:

Tier 1: Includes any publication, statement, resolution, or document released by any of the Nations' official organs or committees; any publication, statement, or document released by a UN member state in its own capacity. The evidence falling in this tier is considered most reliable during the simulation.

Tier 2: Includes: any news article published by any official media source that is owned and controlled by a UN member state. E.g.: Xinhua News (China), Prasar Bharti (India), BBC (United Kingdom) etcetera. The evidence falling in this tier is considered sufficiently reliable in case no other evidence from any Tier 1 source is available on that particular fact, event, or situation.

Tier 3: Includes: any publication from news sources of international repute such as Reuters, The New York Times, Agence-France Presse, etcetera. The evidence falling under this tier is considered the least reliable for the purposes of this simulation. Yet, if no better source is available in a certain scenario, it may be considered.

Foreign Policy and Foreign Relations

Foreign policy, in simple terms, is what your country aims to achieve in regards to the issue
at hand or in general with its relations with other countries.

1. What role must foreign policy play in your research?

Understanding the foreign policy of your country must be a checkbox that you tick off at the very beginning of your research.

Your foreign policy should dictate everything from the arguments you make, the reasoning you give for making those arguments, and the actions you take in the Council.

2. Where do I look to find foreign policy?

Most of the time, foreign policy is not explicitly stated. It must be inferred from the actions and statements issued by the country. Reading the meeting records from previous meetings
of UNSC (or any other UN body where your country might have spoken on the issue) is a great place to start. If such records are unavailable, look for statements from your country's Foreign Ministry (or equivalent like Ministry of External Affairs, Ministry for Foreign Affairs etcetera) and top leadership (PM, Pres., Secretary of State, Defence Minister).
Foreign Relations on the other hand refers to the diplomatic ties that one country has with another and considers elements such as the mutual presence of embassies, consulates, ambassadors & diplomatic dialogue. More often than not, foreign policy is what will be of your primary concern during your MUN but it is important to also consider any extremities in your allotted country's foreign relations.

Rules of Procedure

ROP, or rules of procedure are the set rules to be followed whilst in committee session. Rules of procedure are generally the same for all simulated conferences, and some parts can be amended based on the executive board of that specific conference. Since the ROP is universally followed, the link below will take you to a cheat sheet which you can use for future reference as well. [ROP]

Introduction to the Committee

However, it does not have the power to enforce an action upon any sovereign state but can solely recommend a course of action to the Security Council, members of the United Nation or both, except as provided in article 12 of the UN Charter. Apart from providing recommendations, the General Assembly is tasked with a multitude of different functions which include: the election of judges to the International Court of Justice, the selection of members for the Economic and Social Council, the selection of non-permanent members for the United Nations General Assembly is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations and the only body that commands the presence of all 193 sovereign states. Other entities such as the African Union, the Vatican and Palestine for example maintain an observer status allowing them to participate in the discussions and work of the General Assembly.
The General Assembly convenes once a year, typically around September with sessions lasting close to around three months. However, emergency sessions can also be convened in accordance with UNGA resolution 377A (V) by a simple majority vote by members of the UN or with seven votes from any of the members from the Security Council. The mandate of the General Assembly allows it to discuss any matters that are within the scope of the UN charter allowing it to exercise deliberative, supervisory, financial and elective functions of any regard throughout the charter.

the United Nations Security Council, the appointment process for the Secretary General and the budgetary process for the United Nations to name a few.

While most decisions are based on a simple majority system, a few such as appointing a new member to the General Assembly require a two-thirds majority instead. While during the beginning of the General Assembly's session it does hold a general debate where any member may participate and raise an issue of international concern, most work is done in its six main sub-committees:

- Disarmament and International Security (colloquially referred to as DISEC)
- Economic and Financial (colloquially referred to as ECOFIN)
- Social, Humanitarian and Cultural (colloquially referred to as SOCHUM)
- Special, Political and Decolonisation (colloquially referred to as SPECPOL)
- Administrative & Budgetary
- Legal

Their names are for the most part self-explanatory of the issues that they focus on and are open to all members of the United Nations, each of these committees convene after the General Debate has ended each year and take action via the form of resolutions that are then sent to the General Assembly for voting. Some are unanimous with the support of all members whereas others are highly controversial and amount to heavy amounts of deliberation before consensus is reached.

The Mandate of DISEC

The committee considers all disarmament and international security matters within the scope of the Charter or relating to the powers and functions of any other organ of the United Nations; the general principles of cooperation in the maintenance of international peace and security, as well as principles governing disarmament and the regulation of armaments; promotion of cooperative arrangements and measures aimed at strengthening stability through lower levels of armaments. The Committee works in close cooperation with the United Nations Disarmament Commission and the Geneva-based Conference on Disarmament. It is the only Main Committee of the General Assembly entitled to verbatim records coverage.

What are Nuclear Weapons?

Nuclear weapons are devices that release immense amounts of energy through the processes of nuclear fission and fusion. They are considered the most destructive weapons ever created, capable of causing catastrophic damage to human life, infrastructure, and the environment on an unprecedented scale.

The detonation of a nuclear weapon generates intense heat, powerful shockwaves, and long-lasting radioactive fallout that can have devastating and far-reaching consequences. The explosive yield of nuclear weapons is typically measured in terms of the number of conventional explosives that would be required to produce a similar blast, with the smallest nuclear weapons having a yield equivalent to thousands of tons of TNT.

Nuclear weapons are fundamentally different from conventional explosives, as they derive their destructive power from the splitting or fusing of atomic nuclei. This nuclear reaction releases an enormous amount of energy in a very short time, resulting in a massive explosion. The development of nuclear weapons technology has been a significant milestone in human history, marking a shift towards weapons of mass destruction with unparalleled destructive capabilities.

According to the United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA), there are currently an estimated 13,410 nuclear warheads in the world, with the United States and Russia possessing the largest stockpiles. The possession of nuclear weapons is a highly complex and contentious issue, as they pose grave threats to global peace and security. Nuclear weapons have the potential to cause indiscriminate and disproportionate harm, making them a subject of intense international scrutiny and efforts towards disarmament and non-proliferation.

The development and testing of nuclear weapons have had significant environmental and humanitarian consequences. The detonation of nuclear devices has resulted in the release of radioactive fallout, which can contaminate the surrounding area and have long-lasting effects on human health and the ecosystem. The use of nuclear weapons, even in a limited conflict, could have catastrophic global consequences, leading to widespread destruction, displacement of populations, and long-term environmental damage.

Understanding the nature and impact of nuclear weapons is crucial in addressing the risks of their proliferation, particularly in volatile regions like South Asia. The international community has made efforts to regulate and limit the spread of nuclear weapons through various treaties and agreements, such as the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) and the

Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty (CTBT). However, the challenge of nuclear weapons proliferation remains a significant global concern.

NPT – Obligations & Criticism (NWS vs NNWS)

The Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) is the cornerstone of the global nuclear non-proliferation regime, with the goal of preventing the spread of nuclear weapons and promoting the peaceful use of nuclear energy. The NPT divides countries into two categories: Nuclear-Weapon States (NWS) and Non-Nuclear-Weapon States (NNWS).

NWS, defined as countries that manufactured and exploded a nuclear weapon or other nuclear explosive device before January 1, 1967, are prohibited from transferring nuclear weapons to other states or assisting, encouraging, or inducing NNWS to acquire or develop nuclear weapons. NNWS, on the other hand, are prohibited from receiving, manufacturing, or acquiring nuclear weapons.

The NPT has been criticized for its perceived unfairness, as it allows NWS to maintain their nuclear arsenals while restricting NNWS from developing or acquiring such weapons. Some countries, such as India, Pakistan, and Israel, have not signed the NPT and possess nuclear weapons outside the treaty framework. This has led to concerns about the effectiveness of the NPT in preventing the spread of nuclear weapons, particularly in regions like South Asia where tensions and conflicts have fuelled nuclear proliferation.

According to the United Nations Institute for Disarmament Research (UNIDIR), the NPT has been successful in limiting the spread of nuclear weapons, with only four countries (India, Pakistan, Israel, and North Korea) acquiring nuclear weapons since the treaty's entry into force in 1970. However, the treaty has faced criticism for its inability to address the disarmament obligations of NWS, as they have been slow to fulfil their commitments under Article VI of the treaty. This has undermined the credibility of the non-proliferation regime and fuelled resentment among NNWS, who feel that the treaty is skewed in favour of the nuclear-armed states.

Despite these criticisms, the NPT remains a vital instrument in global efforts to prevent the further spread of nuclear weapons and promote the peaceful use of nuclear technology. The treaty has been widely adopted, with 191 states parties, making it one of the most widely subscribed international agreements. Ongoing efforts to strengthen the NPT and address the concerns of its members are crucial in maintaining the integrity of the global non-proliferation regime.

What constitutes the South Asia region?

The South Asia region, as defined by the United Nations, includes the following countries: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Iran, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka. This diverse region is characterized by complex geopolitical dynamics, unresolved territorial disputes, and the presence of nuclear-armed states, all of which have significant implications for the risk of nuclear weapons proliferation.

The geographical proximity of these countries, their shared history, and the interconnected nature of their security concerns make the South Asia region a critical area of focus for addressing the risk of nuclear weapons proliferation. The region has witnessed several conflicts and tensions, particularly between India and Pakistan, which have contributed to the heightened risk of nuclear escalation.

According to the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI), the South Asia region is home to two nuclear-armed states, India and Pakistan, which together possess an estimated 331 nuclear warheads as of 2022. The presence of these nuclear-armed states, coupled with the ongoing conflicts and territorial disputes, has heightened the risk of nuclear proliferation and the potential for catastrophic consequences in the event of a conflict.

The presence of ongoing conflicts, political instability, and weak governance in some areas of South Asia further exacerbates the challenges in addressing nuclear proliferation. The porous borders, lack of effective border controls, and the potential for corruption within nuclear facilities and programs heighten the risk of nuclear materials or technology being diverted to non-state actors or other countries seeking to acquire nuclear weapons capabilities.

Despite these challenges, the South Asia region has also made efforts towards regional cooperation and confidence-building measures. Organizations like the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) have provided a platform for dialogue and cooperation among the countries in the region. However, the lack of a comprehensive regional security framework or nuclear-weapon-free zone (NWFZ) in South Asia has hindered the development of trust and cooperation among the countries in addressing the risk of nuclear weapons proliferation.

Countries in the South Asia region that possess nuclear weapons

India conducted its first successful nuclear test in 1974, known as "Smiling Buddha," and is estimated to have a stockpile of around 156 nuclear warheads as of 2022. India's nuclear program has been driven by its perceived security threats, particularly from China, and its desire to maintain a credible deterrent. The country has also made efforts to develop

India and Pakistan are the two countries in the South Asia region that are known to possess nuclear weapons. Both countries have conducted successful nuclear tests and are believed to have developed substantial nuclear arsenals.

advanced nuclear technologies, including submarine-launched ballistic missiles and thermonuclear weapons.

According to the Federation of American Scientists (FAS), Pakistan conducted its first nuclear tests in 1998 in response to India's tests. Pakistan is estimated to have a stockpile of around 165 nuclear warheads as of 2022. Pakistan's nuclear program has been primarily motivated by its rivalry with India and the need to counter India's conventional and nuclear superiority. The country has also developed tactical nuclear weapons and short-range ballistic missiles to offset India's conventional military advantage.

The presence of these two nuclear-armed states in the South Asia region has heightened the risk of nuclear proliferation and the potential for catastrophic consequences in the event of a conflict. The unresolved territorial disputes, particularly over the Kashmir region, have further exacerbated the tensions between India and Pakistan, increasing the likelihood of nuclear escalation.

Both India and Pakistan have justified their nuclear programs as a means of deterring aggression and ensuring national security. However, this has led to a cycle of action and reaction, with each side seeking to maintain a perceived strategic advantage. The absence of a comprehensive regional security framework or nuclear-weapon-free zone (NWFZ) in South Asia has further hindered the development of trust and cooperation among the countries in the region.

Threats posed by VNSAs in the region

The presence of violent non-state actors (VNSAs), such as terrorist groups, in the South Asia region raises significant concerns about the potential for nuclear materials or technology to fall into their hands. This could further exacerbate the risk of nuclear proliferation and the possibility of a nuclear attack.

According to a report by the United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism (UNOCT), groups like Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) and Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM), which have been active in the region, have expressed interest in acquiring nuclear weapons or radiological dispersal devices (dirty bombs). The possibility of these groups obtaining nuclear materials or technology from insiders within Pakistan's nuclear program is a major concern, as it could undermine regional and global security efforts.

The threat posed by VNSAs is particularly acute in the South Asia region due to the presence of ongoing conflicts, political instability, and weak governance in some areas. The porous borders, lack of effective border controls, and the potential for corruption within nuclear facilities and programs heighten the risk of nuclear materials or technology being diverted to these groups.

Addressing the threat of VNSAs acquiring nuclear capabilities requires a comprehensive and coordinated approach involving regional and international cooperation, enhanced security measures, and efforts to address the root causes of extremism and terrorism in the region. Failure to effectively mitigate this threat could have catastrophic consequences for regional and global stability.

The international community has taken steps to address the threat of nuclear terrorism, such as the adoption of UN Security Council Resolution 1540 (2004), which obliges states to establish domestic controls to prevent the proliferation of nuclear, chemical, and biological weapons and their means of delivery. However, the implementation of this resolution has been uneven, particularly in regions like South Asia where concerns about national sovereignty and the perceived intrusiveness of monitoring mechanisms have hindered cooperation.

Strengthening international cooperation, intelligence-sharing, and the development of robust physical security and accounting measures for nuclear materials and facilities are crucial in mitigating the risk of nuclear terrorism in the South Asia region. Addressing the underlying drivers of extremism and promoting regional stability and cooperation are also essential components of a comprehensive approach to this challenge.

Scope for the implementation of a NWFZ in South Asia

The establishment of a nuclear-weapon-free zone (NWFZ) in South Asia could potentially help mitigate the risk of nuclear weapons proliferation in the region. A NWFZ would involve legally binding commitments from the countries in the region to refrain from developing, testing, or possessing nuclear weapons.

However, the implementation of a NWFZ in South Asia faces significant challenges, including the unresolved territorial disputes between India and Pakistan and the absence of a comprehensive regional security framework. The participation of nuclear-armed states outside the region, such as China, would also be crucial for the success of a NWFZ, but their willingness to engage in such an initiative remains uncertain.

Past efforts to establish a NWFZ in South Asia have been met with resistance from India and Pakistan, who have been unwilling to relinquish their nuclear capabilities, citing national security concerns. The lack of trust and cooperation among the countries in the region has further hindered the progress towards a NWFZ, as they have been unable to reach a consensus on the terms and conditions of such an agreement.

Despite these challenges, the potential benefits of a NWFZ in South Asia, such as reducing regional tensions, enhancing security, and contributing to global nuclear disarmament efforts, make it a worthy goal to pursue. However, any successful implementation will require a comprehensive and collaborative approach that addresses the complex geopolitical dynamics, builds trust among the stakeholders, and ensures the participation and commitment of all the relevant countries in the region.

Role of IAEA & NSG in de-escalating the tensions

The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) plays a crucial role in monitoring and verifying the peaceful use of nuclear energy by its member states. The IAEA safeguards system helps ensure that nuclear materials and facilities are not diverted for the production of nuclear weapons, making it an essential component of the global non-proliferation regime.

In the context of South Asia, the IAEA's role in providing technical assistance, conducting inspections, and promoting transparency can contribute to deescalating regional tensions and reducing the risk of nuclear weapons proliferation. By ensuring compliance with international norms and standards, the IAEA can help build confidence among the countries in the region and facilitate dialogue on nuclear-related issues.

The Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) is another important international organization that can play a role in deescalating tensions in South Asia. The NSG is a group of nuclear supplier countries that maintain export guidelines for nuclear-related materials and technology, with the aim of preventing nuclear exports for military purposes and ensuring that nuclear trade for peaceful purposes does not contribute to the proliferation of nuclear weapons.

By maintaining strict export controls and promoting the peaceful use of nuclear technology, the NSG can help mitigate the risk of nuclear materials or technology being diverted for military purposes in the South Asia region. Additionally, the NSG's engagement with the countries in the region can foster cooperation and build trust, which can contribute to the overall efforts towards nuclear non-proliferation and disarmament.

However, the effectiveness of the IAEA and the NSG in deescalating tensions in South Asia is contingent on the willingness of the countries in the region to cooperate and comply with international norms and standards. The complex geopolitical dynamics and the presence of nuclear-armed states in the region pose significant challenges that require a comprehensive and collaborative approach involving these international organizations, the countries in the region, and the broader international community.

Geopolitical tensions in the region

India and Pakistan crossed the nuclear Rubicon in May 1998. The aftermath saw a spectrum of reaction ranging from expressing concerns, condemnation to imposition of sanctions.

Although the concept of a nuclear weapon-free zone was already a dead letter by the time the explosions took place, it nevertheless highlighted the fact that India had tried to explain in the context of the proposal for denuclearisation of South Asia; that nuclear weapons is not a regional issue and that China is integral to any solution to South Asian security issues. Further, Pakistan's refusal to reciprocate India's no-first use pledge in the light of the latter's what it considers "conventional superiority" also gives an insight into the sincerity of the former's intentions behind such proposals.

As far as Pakistan's motives behind the proposal for a nuclear weapon-free zone are concerned, part of the explanation is already clear from the above. It was a diplomatic move intended to mask its own bomb plan for 1972. Thus, while Pakistan had already launched the "peace initiative" in 1972, the Indian explosion provided it with an opportunity to build up the image of a "peace-seeker" in the region. Pakistan's arguments of threat to security from a nuclear India could have appeared logical had its own intentions not come to light. After the discovery of Pakistan's efforts at acquiring nuclear capability, the United States and Canada had suspended aid, but after the Soviet invasion in Afghanistan, Pakistan exploited the "threat" factor against the Soviets. Thus, while Pakistan has, on the one hand, exploited the factor successfully, on the other, it made use of the proposal for establishing a nuclear weapon-free zone in South Asia to reinforce its claims.

Coming to India's rejection of the proposal, the solution was aimed only at South Asia and excluded China (deliberately). Pakistan knew too well that in the given state of Sino-Pak relations, India would never be a party to such a proposal. While India did not express this reason openly, it nevertheless refused the proposal on other grounds - namely, the argument that the proposal should have come from the countries of the region or that South Asia is not
a geographical entity like Latin America, etc. Though the Pakistani proposal was in sharp contrast to the UN study which categorically refers to the need for obtaining a regional consensus before such proposals are brought before the UN, 50 India was not able to take advantage of the situation because of its own explosion of 1974. Pakistan, therefore, to begin with, succeeded in showing India down by scoring diplomatic success in this regard.

What is a Nuclear-Weapon-Free Zone?

A nuclear-weapon-free zone (NWFZ) is a specified region where countries commit themselves not to manufacture, acquire, test, or possess nuclear weapons. Five such zones exist today, four spanning the entire Southern Hemisphere. The regions currently covered under NWFZ agreements include: Latin America (the 1967 Treaty of Tlatelolco), the South Pacific (the 1985 Treaty of Rarotonga), Southeast Asia (the 1995 Treaty of Bangkok) Africa (the 1996 Treaty of Pelindaba), and Central Asia (the 2006 Treaty of Semipalatinsk).

Conceptually speaking, India was right in not accepting the proposal for it was an extension of the NPT. C. Subramaniam, the then Defence Minister, had said," Once the nuclear weapon-free zone is accepted, it will legitimise nuclear weapons in the hands of nuclear weapon powers and will bring an end to the struggle to achieve nuclear disarmament."

Nuclear-Weapon-Free Zones are an important regional approach to strengthening global nuclear non-proliferation and disarmament norms and consolidating international efforts toward peace and security.

Within the respective territories of the zones, the Treaties establishing NWFZs prohibit the acquisition, possession, placement, testing, and use of such weapons.

In addition, States Parties to the Treaties establishing NWFZs are exerting efforts to formalize legally binding agreements that would prevent nuclear-weapon States from using or threatening to use nuclear weapons against any countries that are part of the zones.

Legal Definition

According to the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) resolution 3472 B (1975), a NWFZ is "any zone, recognized as such by the General Assembly of the United Nations, which any group of States, in the free exercise of their sovereignty, has established by virtue of a treaty or a convention whereby the statute of total absence of nuclear weapons, to which the zone should be subjected, is defined and an international system of verification and control is established."3 Thus, NWFZs involve groups of countries cooperating regionally through multilateral agreements to maintain the denuclearized status of the region.

Scope for the Implementation of a NWFZ

India and Pakistan crossed the nuclear Rubicon in May 1998. The aftermath saw a spectrum of reaction ranging from expressing concerns, condemnation to imposition of sanctions. Although the concept of a nuclear weapon-free zone was already a dead letter by the time the explosions took place, it nevertheless highlighted the fact that India had tried to explain in the context of the proposal for denuclearisation of South Asia; that nuclear weapon is not a regional issue and that China is integral to any solution to South Asian security issues. Further, Pakistan's refusal to reciprocate India's no-first use pledge in the light of the latter's what it considers "conventional superiority" also gives an insight into the sincerity of the former's intentions behind such proposals.

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Relevant International Legal Frameworks

Non-Proliferation Treaty

The NPT is an international treaty which aims to prevent the spread of nuclear weapons and weapons technology, to promote peaceful uses of nuclear energy in the global community and to further the goal of achieving nuclear disarmament.Opened for signature in 1968, the Treaty entered into force in 1970. On 11 May 1995, the Treaty was extended indefinitely. A total of 191 States have joined the Treaty, including the five nuclear-weapon States. More countries have ratified the NPT than any other arms limitation and disarmament agreement, a testament to the Treaty’s significance.

The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) is tasked to oversee global nuclear cooperation and also to check for violations of the NPT . Safeguards are used to verify compliance with the Treaty through inspections conducted by the IAEA. The Treaty promotes cooperation in the field of peaceful nuclear technology and equal access to this technology for all States parties, while safeguards prevent the diversion of fissile material for weapons use.

The Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty

The Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty (CTBT) bans all nuclear explosions, whether for military or peaceful purposes. It comprises a preamble, 17 articles, two annexes and a Protocol with two annexes.

Another important text is the Resolution adopted by the States Signatories on 19 November 1996 establishing the Preparatory Commission for the Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty Organisation (CTBTO).

Ithas not come to force yet as eight specific nations have not ratified the treaty.

Obligations under CTBT

Each State Party undertakes not to carry out any nuclear weapon test explosion or any other nuclear explosion, and to prohibit and prevent any such nuclear explosion at any place under its jurisdiction or control.

Each State Party undertakes, furthermore, to refrain from causing, encouraging, or in any way participating in the carrying out of any nuclear weapon test explosion or any other nuclear explosion.

Fissile material cut-off treaty (FMCT)

A fissile material cut-off treaty (FMCT) is a proposed international agreement that would prohibit the production of the two main components of nuclear weapons: highly-enriched uranium (HEU) and plutonium. Discussions on this subject have taken place at the UN Conference on Disarmament (CD), a body of 65 member nations established as the sole multilateral negotiating forum on disarmament. The CD operates by consensus and is often stagnant, impeding progress on an FMCT.

Those nations that joined the nuclear Non proliferation Treaty (NPT) as non-weapon states are already prohibited from producing or acquiring fissile material for weapons. An FMCT would provide new restrictions for the five recognized nuclear weapon states (NWS - United States, Russia, United Kingdom, France, and China), and for the four nations that are not NPT members (Israel, India, Pakistan, and North Korea).

Global Fissile Stockpile Estimates

The United States, the United Kingdom, France, and Russia have all declared that they have stopped producing fissile material for nuclear weapons. It is widely believed that China has also stopped producing fissile material for nuclear weapons, ceasing production of highly enriched uranium (HEU) in 1987, and plutonium in 1991.

According to the International Panel on Fissile Material's (IPFM) 2015 Global Fissile Material Report, the global stockpile of HEU in 2015 consisted of roughly 1,340 ± 125 tons, which would be enough material to create 76,000 first simple, first-generation nuclear weapons. Roughly 99% of the HEU stock is owned by nuclear weapon states, and Russia and the United States have the largest stocks. India, Pakistan, and North Korea are believed to have ongoing production operations for HEU.

Points of Contention

In order for negotiations to begin on an FMCT, Pakistan will have to remove its opposition vote, and a consensus to move forward with negotiations must be reached. Pakistan has been primarily concerned that an FMCT would lock them into a disadvantageous position relative to India's superior nuclear stockpile. Consequently, Islamabad would like an FMCT to include current fissile material stockpiles, instead of just capping future production, a position shared by several other countries.

	Highly Enriched Uranium (HEU)	Weapon Grade Plutonium
United States	1992	1987
Russia	1987-88	1994
United Kingdom	1963	1989
France	1996	1992
China	1987-89*	1990*
India	Ongoing	Ongoing
Israel	Status Unknown	Ongoing
Pakistan	Ongoing	Ongoing
North Korea**	Status Unknown	Ongoing

Partial Test Ban Treaty (PTBT)

In 1954, India made the first proposal calling for an agreement to ban nuclear weapons tests. In 1958, the United States, the Soviet Union, and the United Kingdom began a Conference on the Discontinuance of Nuclear Tests in Geneva, aimed at reaching agreement on an effectively controlled test ban. The Conference did not come to fruition because the sides could not reach an agreement on the issue of verification procedures. On 5 August 1963, the

Partial Test Ban Treaty (PTBT) also known as the Limited Test Ban Treaty (LTBT) was signed in Moscow by the United States, the Soviet Union, and the United Kingdom.

The Treaty requires Parties to prohibit, prevent, and abstain from carrying out nuclear weapons tests or any other nuclear explosions in the atmosphere, in outer space, under water, or in any other environment if such explosions cause radioactive debris to be present outside the territorial limits of the State that conducts an explosion; to refrain from causing, encouraging, or in any way participating in, the carrying out of any nuclear weapon test explosion, or any other nuclear explosion, anywhere which would take place in any of the above-described environments. The PTBT does not provide for international verification; however, it is understood that each party may do so by its own national technical means.

Questions a Resolution must Answer (QARMA)

- What are the measures that can be taken to ensure that countries like India & Pakistan sign the NPT?
- How would China being a Nuclear Weapons State (under the NPT) and a major part of the South Asia region affect the dynamics of the situation there?
- How will the countries prevent the VNSAs from acquiring or possessing nuclear weapons?
- How would the countries that have not yet signed the NPT deal with the risk of nuclear proliferation in South Asia? (Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Myanmar)
- Will there be an international organization or agency responsible for overseeing and verifying compliance with the NWFZ treaty if established? How will this organization be funded and operated?
- How will the existing treaties (NPT, CTBT, IAEA) help assist the nuclearnon-proliferation in the South Asia region?